How to Stay Bitter Through the Happiest Times

By Anita Liberty

(Pg 3) I am Anita Liberty – Anita Liberty! I am the mouthpiece for the scorned masses. I am the self-appointed spokesperson for the bitter. I am the performance poet who made a name for herself by devoting her entire career to humiliating her ex-boyfriend, Mitchell, in public when he left her for a woman named Heather. I'm a cult heroine, dammit! But now I'm totally messed up.

INTRODUCTION

Humiliating her ex-boyfriend Mitchell in public was a perfectly satisfying career for Anita Liberty, but then she had to go and do something she swore never to do — she got over it. Then, to make matters worse, she fell blissfully in love. And now she's really got problems. What do you do when you are "an angry performance poet" who suddenly finds herself "perilously close to true happiness?"

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(Pg 16-17) He seemed nice

He was smart

And funny.

And cute.

I liked his clothes.

So . . . you had one good date. With someone who ***seemed*** normal. But seemed is the operative word here. You never know. You just never know. I dated someone for three and a half years who ***seemed*** normal. And then he wasn't anymore. In fact, he turned out to be extremely abnormal. **First impressions mean nothing.**

(Pg 18-19) He called the next day.

He left me a message saying that he had a really nice time and asking when he could see me again. Huh? I'm confused. I just seems so . . . so . . . ***normal***.

(Pg 20) He cooked me dinner.

Which was good.

And nothing he said irritated me.

Not slightly.

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Not once
And he kissed me.
That felt nice.
(Pg 23) We saw a movie and he held my hand.
He smiled at me a lot.
He told me I was beautiful.
He bought me a bottle of ginger ale
On the way home.
That's my favorite soda.
Guess what?
It's his, too.

(Pg 38) I'm confused. It's been so long since I've even wanted to pursue a relationship that I've forgotten how to proceed. It's all making me very, very tense.
(PG 42) Thing I wanted before
I don't want anymore
because they don't' involve him.

I want to pay his rent.
I want to lik his stamps
and scramble his eggs.

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I want to gaze at him adoringly,
Even though if anyone sees me
it will completely ruin my reputation.

I want to write the kinds of poems
he deserves to have written about him.
Poems that exalt him.
Poems that boost his confidence.
Poems that publicly glorify him.

I walk down the street
And think about how much I love him
and I feel good about all humanity.

Who the hell am I ?!?!!!!!?
I don't recognize myself.
I'm not the same person I was before I met him.
I'm totally losing my identity.

(Pg 44-45) Well. I'm allowed to enjoy the fact that I'm so close to being happy. I know it won't last and maybe

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that's why I'm savoring it. These rose-colored glasses will shatter. Problems will arise. Flaws will surface. Reality will set in. I would be nervous, but I've never been one to shy away from reality.

(Pg 48) I performed tonight for the first time in front of Good Date. Afterward, people gathered around me, praising, adulating, fawning. I appreciated the accolades, but I wanted to find Good Date. I wanted his adulation, his fawn. I approached him and silently practiced a humble response to his reverence:

"No, really, you really liked it?

You thought it was amazing?

Come on, the best thing you've ever seen on stage?

That can't be true . . .

When I got to him, he took me in his arms and kissed me deeply.

"So, what'd ya think?"

He tells me he thought it was great.

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"And?" I smile.

"And I have a few notes.

"NOTES?"

"Yeah," he says. "We can talk when we get home."

We're gonna talk when we get home, all right. Because clearly he doesn't understand that the last person who tried to give me notes . . . was the first person who tried to give me notes.

(PG 50-51) . . . he said he wasn't criticizing, he just had a few "suggestions." I told him it was too early in our relationship for him to be giving me advice about my work, when I'd been doing my work just fine without him for years. He said that maybe I just couldn't handle constructive criticism and hat that was a good thing to know about me. I said that maybe he was just threatened by my talent and my success and that that was a good thing to know about him. I then asked him what "suggestions" he had. And, ya know, they weren't bad. The guy actually had some good ideas. He then

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went on to tell me, in detail, how funny and smart I was, etc.

(PG 55) I'm the poster girl for the Society to Mistrust the Longevity of a Romantic Relationship (better known as SMLRR) And, yet, here I am. Trusting again. Loving again.

They're going to revoke my membership. And getting reinstated is a bitch.

(Pg 119) We moved in together. No proposal. No promises. Nothing. He told me not to worry, that he wasn't going anywhere. Whew. That's a relief. I just feel like I'm having relationship déjà vu.

I've been here before.
I've given up my apartment.
I've trusted my instincts.
I've trusted someone.

Boyfriend's right. There's no reason to worry. Why would I worry? **IT'S NOT LIKE THE LAST TIME I MOVED IN WITH SOMEONE HE TURNED OUT TO BE A SOCIOPATH OR ANYTHING.**

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(Pg 120) I'm going crazy. Every week that goes by, every romantic dinner, every time Boyfriend reaches for me lovingly, I think, "this is it. It's about to happen. He's going to . . . ask me to marry him." I can't help myself. I can't stop the train I'm on. I loathe the woman I've become.

(Pg 134) I told you so.
What is it about those four words that makes
Them roll so deliciously off the tongue?

I told you so
I told you so.

Left over from the playground
taunting other kids,
Recognizing the position of power
That being able to see into the future affords you.

I knew it!

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I was right!

I'm psychic.

I saw it coming, even if no one else did.

Especially if no one else did.

(Pg 133) We've decided to take a break. I said I didn't want to go on if this wasn't the real deal. He said he didn't want to feel pressured into making one of the biggest decisions of his life.

(Pg 139) If you're in a great relationship
with someone who respects you
and you're ready to get married,
But the person you're with isn't,
Break up with him.
That way you'll eliminate
Any possibility of getting hurt.
Or being happy

(Pg 142) I have to give him his space. I'm not going to call him. He'll call me when he's ready. Right? I just have to patient and wait. (Long pause) Okay. I called

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him. What? I waited. For sixteen whole minutes. He's coming over tonight.

(Pg 145) . . . . I'm engaged!

I have a fiancé.

I'm going to have a husband.

But first I'm going to have a wedding!!!

I'm getting married.

I'm getting married!

(Pg 152) And I'm understandably concerned about how that will affect my work.

(Pg 176) All of a sudden, this whole "getting married" thing seems like a terrible idea. [Why? Because] Our parents must meet. The deal must be approved, notarized and ordained. Fiancé and I would literally rather eat spoonfuls of live ants than sit through an evening of polite conversation with the four people who are responsible for our existences. What if they hate each other? Or, worst-case scenario, **what if they get along**? Plech. I don't want our parents to be in ***cahoots*** with one another. ***Cahoots*** make me cringe.

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(Pg 177) I was starting to have time to waste in therapy.
Filling forty-five minutes was becoming difficult.
Now I won't have to worry.
Nifty.

(Pg 199) Everyone is annoying me. Everyone.
My family, my friends and oh, the King of Infuriation . . .
Fiancé. They can all just go to hell. I don't want to have
a wedding anymore Fiancé and I are fighting like howler
monkeys and I just can't imagine that I'm going to look
over at him on our wedding day and think, "I'm so lucky
to be marrying you" More likely I'm going to look at him
and think, "You're and ass-clown. Why am I marrying an
ass clown?" I hate Fiancé because he asked me to marry
him and it now seems like some horrible, awful mistake.
We started writing our vows last night. . .

(Pg 200) [Here's what I came up with]
I don't know what you're expecting from me,
but I can't promise to be nice and supportive for ever
and ever

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in every possible scenario and situation.
I just can't. You know I don't like to make promises I
can't keep.
However, I can vow to try.
And I will try. Hard.
I vow that I will try to be nice and supportive.
Although, if I'm being completely honest,
some days I might try harder than others.

(Pg 210) My wedding day was a perfect day
Our wedding day was a perfect day.
It was transcendent and pure.
That day changed my standards dramatically.
Because now I know what it's like to experience a
perfect day.
Not alone. Together.

(Pg 3) I have no reason to be angry anymore. And that
makes me angry. I built my entire career on being angry.
It's what I do. It's who I am. What was I thinking?? I
was thinking what society wanted me to think – that
happy was the goal. Little did I know that being happy

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would make me so miserable.

(Pg 215) . . . this time the end is a happy one.

A terribly, terribly happy one.

[Oh, calm down. I'll be back. Just imagine what I'll be like when I have someone camped out in my uterus for nine months . . . It won't be pretty!]

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2020 National Qualifier - MS
IL State Qualifier

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